“WE HAVE NO QUARREL WITH ANYBODY BUT ONLY WANTED TO MAKE THE PEOPLE UNDERSTAND THAT OUR EXISTENCE IS TIED WITH THE FORESTS.”

A woman of substance

Gaura Devi was born in a remote village in the Garhwal region of the Himalayas. Married at the age of twelve and widowed at the age of twenty-two, Devi had to work to support her young son. By the time she was in her fifties, Devi had grown into a well-respected figure in Reni and was even chosen to lead the local Mahila Mandal (women’s group). During her lifetime, landslides and flooding increasingly came to impact people living in the region of Reni, and throughout the Himalayas. These landslides and floods were believed by the residents to be the result of years of deforestation.

The communities that lived in the hills had traditionally relied on being able to access and use the forests for their livelihood. Their right to do so had first been challenged when the British introduced laws that brought the forests under the government’s management. These essentially gave the government the right to fell trees for their own purposes and to sell off parts of the forests to commercial enterprises. These laws continued after Independence, despite the locals’ demands that the government respect their traditional rights.